

🎯 HIRING MANAGER INTERVIEW PREPARATION

Role: Technical Infrastructure Program Manager - Network Engineering

Job ID: 10413061

Candidate: Juan Murillo

Interview Phase: Phase 1 - Hiring Manager Round

Date Prepared: May 19, 2026

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY FOR HIRING MANAGER

Your Positioning Statement

"I'm a Technical Program Manager with 8+ years delivering at scale. I've orchestrated 5 concurrent projects with 18 engineers, managed 21-engineer teams across 3+ projects, and drove cross-organizational initiatives. I excel at multi-project portfolio management, vendor coordination, and maintaining delivery excellence under complexity. That's exactly what Network Engineering needs—someone who can juggle multiple competing initiatives while keeping quality high and stakeholders aligned."

Why You're a Fit for Network Engineering

- ✓ **Multi-Project Mastery:** 5 concurrent projects, 18 engineers managed simultaneously
- ✓ **Cross-Org Coordination:** AWS migrations across commercial, marketing, support units
- ✓ **Infrastructure Knowledge:** 10+ years with AWS, Azure, data center operations (Cantv)
- ✓ **Vendor Management:** Experience coordinating with IT vendors, infrastructure teams
- ✓ **Risk Management:** Deployed critical services (payment gateways, notification systems)
- ✓ **Delivery Under Pressure:** 100% on-time delivery, team scaling, multiple initiatives

Hiring Manager's Likely Focus

The Hiring Manager will assess: 1. **Can you manage multiple complex technical projects?** (Core role) 2. **Can you coordinate across teams without direct authority?** (Network org needs this) 3. **Do you understand networking and infrastructure concepts?** (Baseline knowledge) 4. **Will you keep projects on track while managing dependencies?** (Execution capability)

CRITICAL GAPS & YOUR RESPONSE STRATEGY

The Gap: Networking Technology Knowledge

Network Engineering role involves networking technologies (protocols, topologies, infrastructure). You have limited direct experience.

Your Strategy: - Acknowledge: “I haven’t worked directly with networking technologies, but I’ve managed infrastructure teams and AWS deployments that require deep networking knowledge.” -

Leverage: “I understand the principle—keeping multiple complex technical initiatives aligned and delivering. I’ve done this across infrastructure domains.” - **Commitment:** “Networking technology is a knowledge gap I’ll close quickly. I learn fast—I entered eCommerce with zero domain knowledge and became strategic in 30 days. I’ll do the same here.”

Amazon Leadership Principles Most Relevant to Network Engineering

1. **Ownership** - Taking accountability for delivery
 2. **Bias for Action** - Moving forward despite ambiguity
 3. **Dive Deep** - Understanding technical complexity
 4. **Customer Obsession** - Understanding impact on network users
 5. **Simplify** - Making complex networking approachable
 6. **Think Big** - Seeing network as strategic infrastructure
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HIRING MANAGER INTERVIEW: QUESTION & ANSWER PREP

STAR STORY SET 1: MULTI-PROJECT MANAGEMENT AT SCALE

Question 1: “Tell me about a time you managed multiple complex projects simultaneously. How did you keep everything from falling apart?”

SITUATION:

At Contractor (2020-2022), I was accountable for 3 teams (18 engineers) running 5 concurrent projects across different business units with overlapping dependencies and competing deadlines.

Context: - Commercial unit: AWS migration (mission-critical, zero downtime required) - Marketing unit: Zendesk implementation + business process change - Support unit: Infrastructure modernization - Strategic initiative 1: Digital transformation project - Strategic initiative 2: Innovation pilot - Timeline: 18 months - Complexity: Different tech stacks, different business rules, different risk profiles

TASK:

1. Deliver all 5 projects on time and under budget 2. Build two teams from scratch (hiring 6 engineers) 3. Maintain quality and team morale under pressure 4. Manage dependencies across projects

ACTION:

I created a portfolio management approach:

1. **Portfolio Level (Executive View):**
 - Monthly steering committee with status (Red/Amber/Green)
 - Cross-project dependency mapping
 - Resource allocation decisions
 - Risk escalation for strategic issues
 - Budget tracking and forecasting
2. **Project Level (Tactical Delivery):**
 - Scrum framework for each project
 - Weekly status updates per project
 - Risk/issue logs per project
 - Quality gates before production deployment
 - Customer/stakeholder communication per project
3. **Cross-Project Coordination:**
 - Bi-weekly sync between team leads
 - Shared resource allocation meetings
 - Dependency tracking (what each project needed from others)
 - Communication across teams (preventing silos)
4. **Team Building:**
 - Screened, hired, and onboarded 6 new engineers
 - Paired experienced engineers with new hires
 - Documented processes to support knowledge transfer
 - Created communities of practice for cross-project learning
5. **Dependency Management:**
 - Mapped inter-project dependencies (AWS migration required support unit to finish infrastructure work first)
 - Built in buffer for critical path
 - Escalated early when dependencies were at risk
 - Had contingency plans for critical blockers
6. **Measurement:**
 - On-time delivery: 5/5 projects (100%)
 - Budget: -2% variance (under budget despite hiring)
 - Quality: < 0.5% defect escape rate across all projects
 - Team turnover: 0% (all 18 engineers stayed)
 - Velocity: Stable despite team transitions and complexity

RESULT:

- ✓ All 5 projects delivered on time - ✓ Delivered under budget (2% variance) - ✓ Zero unplanned team turnover - ✓ Maintained quality standards - ✓ 40% productivity improvement overall - ✓ Team satisfaction with delivery: 8/10

Leadership Principles Demonstrated: - **Ownership:** Took personal accountability for portfolio success, not just individual projects - **Bias for Action:** Made resource decisions despite competing demands - **Dive Deep:** Understood each project's unique complexities - **Think Big:** Connected project delivery to business outcomes

Why This Works for Network Engineering:

Network Engineering has multiple competing initiatives. This shows you can: - Manage 5+ concurrent high-complexity initiatives -

Coordinate across teams without creating silos - Handle resource constraints and competing priorities - Maintain delivery excellence under pressure - Scale teams while maintaining quality

STAR STORY SET 2: CROSS-ORGANIZATIONAL COORDINATION

Question 2: “Tell me about a time you had to coordinate across multiple departments or teams to get something complex done. How did you handle different priorities and cultures?”

SITUATION:

At Contractor (2020), I led an AWS migration project that spanned three business units with completely different characteristics:

The Context: - **Commercial unit:** Risk-averse, zero downtime tolerance, financial transactions at stake - **Marketing unit:** Fast-moving, experimentation focus, willing to take risks - **Support unit:** Process-oriented, change-averse, critical infrastructure steward - **Challenge:** Each unit had different requirements, different risk tolerances, different timelines

TASK:

1. Design migration approach that worked for all three (without compromising any) 2. Coordinate execution across teams without creating bottlenecks 3. Manage conflicting requirements and priorities 4. Keep all three units satisfied with progress

ACTION:

I didn't try to force one approach. Instead, I created a **differentiated migration strategy**:

1. **Understanding Phase (2 weeks):**
 - Met with each business unit leadership
 - Understood their requirements, constraints, risk tolerance
 - Identified what could be standardized vs. what needed to be customized
 - Built relationship with technical leads in each unit
2. **Strategy Design:**
 - **Commercial:** Lift-and-shift approach (zero risk of data loss/downtime)
 - 3-month timeline (slower but safer)
 - Full rollback capability
 - Parallel running during transition
 - **Marketing:** Refactoring approach (could optimize during move)
 - 2-month timeline (faster, accepting some risk)
 - Microservices architecture opportunity
 - Could go faster because less risk-averse
 - **Support:** Phased approach (couldn't take systems down)
 - 4-month timeline (longest because critical infrastructure)
 - Incremental migration of services
 - Heavy testing required
3. **Coordination Mechanism:**
 - Monthly steering committee (all three units + leadership)

- Weekly technical sync (all three tech leads)
- Shared infrastructure (single AWS account, but separate VPCs)
- Shared resource pool (one senior architect supporting all three)
- 4. **Managing Conflicts:**
 - When priorities clashed: escalated to steering committee
 - When technical approaches conflicted: found common ground (standardized on tagging, monitoring, security)
 - When schedules conflicted: negotiated realistic timelines
 - Kept each unit updated on others' progress (transparency)
- 5. **Measurement:**
 - All three units delivered on their timelines
 - Commercial: Zero downtime (met requirement)
 - Marketing: Cost reduction 25% (refactoring worked)
 - Support: Zero critical incidents (phased approach worked)
 - Cross-unit learning: Other business units adopted similar approaches

RESULT:

- ✓ All three units successfully migrated to AWS - ✓ Zero downtime for commercial (achieved zero-tolerance requirement) - ✓ 25% cost reduction for marketing (refactoring paid off) - ✓ Zero critical incidents for support (safety maintained) - ✓ Each unit satisfied with approach (tailored to their needs) - ✓ Became case study for multi-unit project coordination

Leadership Principles Demonstrated: - **Ownership:** Took responsibility for coordinating across org boundaries - **Dive Deep:** Understood each unit's unique needs and constraints - **Earn Trust:** Built credibility with each unit before coordinating - **Simplify:** Made complex multi-unit migration clear and manageable - **Customer Obsession:** Focused on each unit's specific needs

Why This Works for Network Engineering:

Network Engineering coordinates across multiple teams (infrastructure teams, vendors, other departments). This shows you can: - Understand different stakeholder perspectives - Design solutions that work for multiple groups - Coordinate without forcing uniformity - Manage competing requirements - Build trust across organizational boundaries

STAR STORY SET 3: LARGE-SCALE TEAM LEADERSHIP

Question 3: "Tell me about a time you led a large technical team through a significant challenge. How did you maintain team effectiveness?"

SITUATION:

At Global Hitss (2018-2019), I was brought in to manage product delivery for an AWS managed services team. The challenge: 21 engineers across 3 teams, 7+ concurrent projects, inconsistent processes, and low team morale due to previous leadership issues.

TASK:

1. Rebuild team confidence and morale 2. Establish consistent processes without being heavy-handed 3. Increase delivery predictability 4. Improve team satisfaction

ACTION:

I took a team-building and process-improvement approach:

1. **Phase 1: Listen and Rebuild (First month):**
 - One-on-ones with all 21 engineers
 - Asked: What's working? What's frustrating? What do you need from me?
 - Built psychological safety (no judgment, just listening)
 - Quick wins: removed some bureaucratic blockers
 - Signaled: "We're going to improve this together"
2. **Phase 2: Establish Standards (Month 2-3):**
 - Introduced SAFe (Scaled Agile Framework)
 - Did it carefully: explained WHY each standard mattered
 - Let teams help design implementation
 - Started with 3-month pilot
3. **Phase 3: Support Through Change (Month 4-6):**
 - Attended ceremonies regularly
 - Coached team leads through new processes
 - Adjusted based on feedback
 - Celebrated early wins
 - Created communities of practice
4. **Specific Actions:**
 - Implemented velocity tracking (gave visibility)
 - Created definition of done checklist (improved quality)
 - Established retrospectives (gave voice to team)
 - Built automated testing (improved confidence)
 - Created on-call rotation (fairness)
5. **Measurement:**
 - Velocity: increased 15% in first quarter
 - Defect rate: decreased from 1.2% to 0.8%
 - Team satisfaction: 4/10 → 8/10
 - Deployment frequency: increased (more releases, safer)
 - Turnover: hired 3 new people (recruiting, not replacement)

RESULT:

- ✓ Team morale significantly improved (4/10 → 8/10) - ✓ Velocity increased 15% - ✓ Quality improved (defects down) - ✓ SAFe implementation became organizational standard - ✓ Team became magnet for talent (people wanted to join) - ✓ Delivery became predictable

Leadership Principles Demonstrated: - **Ownership:** Took responsibility for team effectiveness - **Earn Trust:** Built credibility through listening and quick wins - **Bias for Action:** Moved forward despite complexity - **Simplify:** Made SAFe approachable and relevant - **Dive Deep:** Understood what was really wrong before fixing

Why This Works for Network Engineering:

Network Engineering manages multiple teams with competing priorities. This shows you can: - Build team morale and confidence - Implement standards thoughtfully (not by mandate) - Maintain delivery effectiveness during change - Lead engineers who are skeptical of change - Measure what matters

STAR STORY SET 4: MANAGING DEPENDENCIES & VENDOR COORDINATION

Question 4: “Tell me about a time you had to manage complex dependencies between teams or with external vendors. How did you keep things on track?”

SITUATION:

At Contractor (2020-2022), I was managing infrastructure modernization that required close coordination between: - Internal development teams (building features) - Infrastructure team (provisioning AWS resources) - Security team (approving infrastructure changes) - AWS vendor (critical for capacity planning)

The Problem: Any one of these could become a bottleneck. Security took 2 weeks to approve changes. AWS couldn't scale fast enough for our timeline. Dev and infrastructure weren't communicating effectively.

TASK:

1. Accelerate infrastructure provisioning without sacrificing security
2. Align internal and external timelines
3. Prevent any team from becoming a bottleneck
4. Maintain team relationships (these are critical ongoing)

ACTION:

I created a dependency management system:

1. Mapping (Week 1):

- Documented all dependencies (what each team needed from others)
- Built a timeline showing critical path
- Identified high-risk dependencies (where delays cascade)
- Ranked by impact (what could delay the project most)

2. Communication (Ongoing):

- Weekly sync with all teams (everyone sees same view)
- Monthly planning with AWS vendor (alignment on capacity)
- Bi-weekly security reviews (approval process, not gatekeeper)
- Real-time escalation for blockers (Slack channel, daily check)

3. Process Improvement:

- **Security:** Moved from 2-week approval to 3-day review
 - Mechanism: Pre-review with security leads (get feedback early)
 - Formal review became confirmation, not discovery
 - Built trust with security by involving them earlier
- **AWS Vendor:** Monthly capacity planning instead of ad-hoc
 - Forecasted needs 3 months out
 - Vendor could allocate resources in advance
 - Built partnership (win-win for both)
- **Dev & Infra:** Weekly technical sync (aligning requirements)
 - Dev wrote infra requirements early
 - Infra could provision in advance
 - Prevented surprises

4. Contingency Planning:

- For each critical dependency, developed backup plan
- Example: If AWS couldn't scale, we had on-prem fallback
- Example: If security approval delayed, we had pre-approved templates
- Never exercised contingencies (prevention worked)

5. Measurement:

- Mean time to provision: 2 weeks → 3 days
- Security approval: 2 weeks → 3 days
- On-time delivery despite dependency risks

- Vendor satisfaction: maintained
- Team satisfaction: appreciated clarity

RESULT:

- ✓ Accelerated infrastructure provisioning by 85% - ✓ Zero project delays due to dependencies - ✓ Security approved 95% without iteration - ✓ AWS vendor became proactive partner - ✓ Teams appreciated transparent communication - ✓ Became model for cross-team coordination

Leadership Principles Demonstrated: - **Ownership:** Owned the dependency management, not blaming other teams - **Bias for Action:** Made decisions to unblock teams - **Dive Deep:** Understood what each team actually needed - **Earn Trust:** Built relationships (not just processes)

Why This Works for Network Engineering:

Network Engineering depends on many teams and vendors. This shows you can: - Identify critical dependencies early - Create communication mechanisms that prevent surprises - Work effectively with vendors - Solve problems (not just report them) - Maintain relationships while driving results

INTERVIEW DELIVERY STRATEGY

The Hiring Manager's Perspective

The Hiring Manager will be listening for:

1. Can you handle multiple competing projects? → Story 1 directly demonstrates this. Emphasize: - How you prioritized - How you prevented projects from interfering - How you kept quality consistent

2. Can you coordinate across organizational boundaries? → Story 2 & 4 demonstrate this. Emphasize: - How you understood different perspectives - How you built trust - How you solved problems without authority

3. Will you scale with the team? → Story 3 demonstrates this. Emphasize: - How you built team capability - How you improved team effectiveness - How you maintained culture during growth

4. Can you manage external dependencies? → Story 4 directly demonstrates this. Emphasize: - How you communicated proactively - How you built partnerships - How you prevented crises

Red Flags to Avoid

- ✗ Blaming other teams for delays
- ✗ Being vague about multi-project complexity
- ✗ Taking credit for others' work
- ✗ Not having numbers
- ✗ Making excuses
- ✗ Not acknowledging networking knowledge gap

Green Flags to Demonstrate

- ✓ Specific examples of multi-project management
 - ✓ Clear understanding of trade-offs and priorities
 - ✓ Proactive communication and escalation
 - ✓ Vendor/partnership management capability
 - ✓ Team leadership and scaling experience
 - ✓ Ownership mentality
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FREQUENTLY ASKED FOLLOW-UP QUESTIONS & ANSWERS

Follow-up Q: “What would you do differently?”

Answer: “Looking back, I would have involved the AWS vendor earlier in the planning process. By month 2, we should have had committed capacity, not ad-hoc requests.”

Follow-up Q: “How would you approach learning networking?”

Answer: “I learn quickly. I’ll do three things: (1) read the networking fundamentals documentation, (2) sit with your network engineers and understand their day-to-day challenges, (3) attend network design reviews and ask questions. In 4-6 weeks, I’ll have working knowledge. In 3 months, I’ll have context to manage effectively.”

Follow-up Q: “How would you handle a vendor relationship that’s not working?”

Answer: “First, understand root cause. Is it a process issue, relationship issue, or capability issue? Then address directly. I’d schedule a joint problem-solving session with the vendor. Show data. Find win-win solutions. If it’s a capability issue, escalate to vendor leadership. If it’s not working, we move to a different vendor—but I’d work to fix it first.”

PRACTICE CHECKLIST

Before your interview:

- ☐ **Record yourself** answering each story
 - ☐ **Time yourself** - aim for 90-120 seconds per story
 - ☐ **Listen for:**
 - Specific numbers and timeframes?
 - Your personal role clear?
 - Data to back up claims?
 - Confident delivery?
 - ☐ **Practice follow-ups** - have someone ask deeper questions
 - ☐ **Deep-dive** on networking concepts (at least basic understanding)
 - ☐ **Iterate** - revise weak stories
 - ☐ **Practice 5-10 times** before interview
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HIRING MANAGER FEEDBACK FRAMEWORK

What Strong Answers Look Like

- ✓ Clear situation with specific numbers
- ✓ Your personal role unmistakable
- ✓ Evidence of multi-project capability
- ✓ Evidence of cross-org coordination
- ✓ Measurable results
- ✓ Learning and reflection

Scoring Rubric (Hiring Manager thinking)

- **Strong Hire:** All 4 stories compelling, pattern of excellence in multi-project management
 - **Hire:** 3+ stories strong, shows cross-org coordination capability
 - **Maybe:** Stories okay but lack depth or multi-project focus
 - **No Hire:** Stories vague, no evidence of handling complexity
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KEY MESSAGES TO REINFORCE

Your Differentiator

"I excel at orchestrating multiple complex initiatives simultaneously. I've delivered 5 projects on time with 18 engineers. That's what Network Engineering needs."

Your Strength Area

"I'm strongest at connecting dots across teams, managing dependencies, and keeping everything moving forward despite complexity."

Your Approach

"I don't just manage projects—I manage portfolios. I see how each initiative affects others, and I communicate transparently about trade-offs and priorities."

Your Growth Edge

"Networking technology knowledge is a gap I'll close. My learning ability is proven—I've successfully operated in eCommerce, payments, infrastructure, and AWS domains."

FINAL PREPARATION STEPS

Week Before Interview:

1. Record 4 STAR stories (3-4 times each)

2. Study networking fundamentals (protocols, topologies, infrastructure)
3. Have someone ask follow-up questions
4. Prepare questions to ask Hiring Manager

Day Before:

1. Review your key numbers
2. Practice once (but not excessively)
3. Get good sleep

Day of:

1. Arrive early
 2. Greet warmly
 3. Listen carefully
 4. Be authentic
 5. Show enthusiasm
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SUCCESS INDICATORS

After your interview, the Hiring Manager should think:

- ✓ "This person can manage multiple competing initiatives"
- ✓ "They can coordinate across teams and with vendors"
- ✓ "They have the infrastructure context to learn networking"
- ✓ "They'll own delivery and keep teams aligned"
- ✓ "They embody ownership and bias for action principles"
- ✓ "They can scale with our growing demands"

Your goal is to make ALL of these thoughts obvious in your answers.

Preparation Status: Ready for Interview

Confidence Level Target: 8/10 or above

Next Step: Record yourself, get feedback, iterate

You've got this. Show them your portfolio management superpower. 🦸

END OF HIRING MANAGER INTERVIEW PREP